

OLIVIER TOURING TREASURES EDIT

Travel Radio Australia and we're here with Olivier Messiaen-Ferrol and he is the co-founder and executive director at Touring Treasures covering Australia, New Zealand and the South Pacific. Olivier, welcome to the program. Hi, nice to have me.

Now, Olivier, tell us a bit about the background of this company. It's a fantastic bespoke luxury company. You can look after people's experiences in all those places I talk about.

First of all, tell us a bit of a general overview of the company itself. Yes, so Touring Treasures is a destination management company. So basically we design luxury vacation holidays for international travelers coming from all over the world.

Touring Treasures, you know, philosophy is really to design those itineraries that suit perfectly the profile of our clients. We like to know about them and really provide experiences that are meaningful. And we have a beautiful, beautiful destination like Australia, New Zealand and South Pacific, you know, where we can really create some amazing experiences for those people.

So we are lucky, it's a beautiful part of the world and that's basically what we like to do. It's a fabulous range of places that you can arrange people to visit. In Australia, of course, we have Victoria, New South Wales, Queensland, South Australia, Northern Territory, Western Australia and Tasmania.

In New Zealand, the North and South Island and I personally have been out to the South Pacific because I used to be a DJ on a cruise ship on SITMAR back in the early 80s. So I know that whole region around there, the Fijian Islands, Port Vila, the Noumea, all those sorts of places. And I suppose you're an expert on that, those places too.

You've been out there a lot. Yes, so part of our tough work, I would say, and lifestyle is to discover those places, visit them regularly so that we can offer our clients, you know, the best experiences and advice as well. So it's very important things change, hotels develop in a certain way.

So it's very important to pulse of what's going on in each of these regions. So half of the time we spend on meeting our clients overseas and the other half is really spending on each destination. You mentioned Australia with all the different states.

I mean, we have great partners as well, sometimes inform us about information that are quite valuable to us. And then that enables us to through this network is really to be up to date all the time. We know what we like to sell, how we like to sell it, the people we like to work with.

This is very important because everybody's different, you know, in this world, everybody travels in different ways. So we need to have a panel and portfolio product that suits people. And

sometimes we start things from scratch.

What's interesting as well is connecting with those people. Sometimes it's not big, it's not, you know, we're in luxury, but we're not after the bling bling, but some people have so much to offer and tell stories about a destination. And that's what we're really after.

So travel in those places is something we do regularly. It's part of our, and that's why people come to us. They want to, for example, just before our meeting, we met with an agent who said, okay, Olivia, I know what you do and I'd love, this is my best clients and this is their profile.

How can we make their trips special? So he had already prepared because he knows that he had already prepared a list of, you know, all the things they like, they don't like, and so on. So we're going to take this and build from there. So yeah, product knowledge is very key.

It's something that is on top of our list all the time. It's like a chef. I always say, you know, it's a chef goes to the market, meet the farmers and pick up the right products.

And at the end, he puts all this together and create an amazing dish, like let's say a Michelin star dish. And then that's what we do. So product training and visiting those places and connecting with the people as well, because at the end of the day, it's all about people, something that we do regularly and we love it.

You do groups for anywhere from what, two people up? What's your average size of groups that you do? Mainly we call what we call FIT. So we do mainly couples, family of four or five, but post COVID, we realized that the size of the passengers increased because we had a lot of families traveling together after all this separation. So grandpa, grandma, the kids, the grandkids.

So we sometimes go up to 10, 12 people. It happens that we had some special group up to 20, but that's, I would say that's the max for touring treasures in terms of size. We vary much from two to 20, because above that, there are some experiences that you can't do.

There are certain things that you just, you know, eight max or whatever. And so that's where we stay within that space. And you want to keep it personal too, don't you? And I mean, you get to know the people one-on-one and if you had groups of 30, 50, you wouldn't get, they wouldn't get to know you as well.

We had one exception when we had that group of 35 at the beginning of the year. And then what we did is we basically divided the group when there were experiences. So we did it in a clever way.

So there were basically, you know, 10 max and they could enjoy each and then we were turning it over three days, those kinds of things. So, but, but most of the time it's really between two and eight. And this is where you can really immerse in those experiences in a way.

Yeah. And tell me about some of your favorite places to take these groups. Now I've noticed you've got the 12 Apostles here on the great ocean road in Victoria and Lizard Island, North Queensland.

Are there some fantastic destinations? Oh, there's amazing destination. Actually just wrote an article of the best way to, to discover the Whitsundays. This is a beautiful part of, of, of, of Queensland and Australia, of course, on a super route, which we organized that for some client servers.

Beautiful experience. We love, we love the art back as well. You know, you can hear my accent as a French for me.

That's always like this, this part of Australia, which is so unique, you know, with this right there, the movie Crocodile Dundee was just opening that, you know, that, and actually, you know, going to Darwin and the Kakadu and Harlem land, this is so amazing places. So this is all those, the Kimberley's is just stunning. South Australia with the food, Kangaroo Island with the, you know, the wilderness.

Tasmania is just stunning place as well. I mean, so many Australia is, is a big country with a diverse city, which is really exceptional for, from my perspective. Anywhere there is something special.

And that's what I love about this country from north to south, southwest to east. There's something special to see. And look, we've been operating since 2003, and we're still discovering things today.

And the level of service, the quality of the experiences, the type of product, even the food and wine has improved drastically. Best place to eat, I would go to South Australia and enjoy all those beautiful dishes and wineries and all, you know, I mean, you name it. Margaret River is fantastic as well in that part.

It's diverse and there's so much to see. And I understand the people, you know, take a year and so on with the caravan traveling and discovering. But another place you take people to is New Zealand and tell us about some of the experiences they can do there with you.

Yes. So New Zealand is very interesting in terms of the subtlety. It's not so far from Australia, but it's such a different country.

It's more about the landscapes, the beautiful, the beautiful people and then the Maori culture. So we like to, we like to send people, for example, to the North Island and discover Bay of Islands, which is, which is stunning. Staying at places like the Landing or Kariklis, you know, if you want to play golf and enjoying something really special.

A short stay in Auckland, maybe stop by Waiiki Island and then, you know, discover this beautiful island and then continue to Taupo and getting closer to what we call this, all the volcanic part of us, of New Zealand. Obviously, Ukaloge is a beautiful place to stay once in Taupo. Napier is a stunning, stunning with art deco and obviously, Ted Kinappers, which is quite a great place.

So we love as well, I mean, the North Island of, the north of the South Island of New Zealand with Marlborough Sound, Nelson and all this, this region is really beautiful. I mean, going down after that to Kaikoura with the whales and then you continue down to Christchurch and then crossing as well, going to Archer Path and, you know, to the south. It's all those regions, it's beautiful, we love it.

Beautiful lodge, what we like to send our clients is Blanken Bay in Queenstown. So it's a beautiful, beautiful lodge, Minaret Station, which can only be accessible by helicopter, but I just love when the helicopter drop us a bit further and then we just walk down all the way to the lodge. What a beautiful lodge in the middle of nowhere, it's just on the place and then you just enjoy nature and then they greet you and then even take care of your shoes, clean your shoes and then welcome you around a fire and a nice hot chocolate or tea, it's just fantastic.

So food obviously is really, really, really nice. We like to organise as well some beautiful experience by helicopter all the way to Milford Sound, landing on the boat, you know, having the boat for yourself, a nice morning tea and then you fly again and stay on the glacier, having a picnic, beautiful, you know, wine tasting or spirits tasting. It's just stunning, you're on your own with the helicopter and the pilot and then you enjoy that beautiful view, it's just stunning.

New Zealand is really a beautiful place for all those things, yeah. Now we're speaking to Olivier Mercier and Ferrol, the co-founder and executive director at Touring Treasures, based in Brisbane, Australia. Olivier and his team can take care of all of your bespoke luxury travel requirements for all of Australia, New Zealand and the South Pacific.

Olivier, just briefly tell me a bit about your background, how did you get into this, were you in travel before you started your own company? That's a good question, so we started, created Touring Treasures in 2003 and at that time I was working in corporate finance, so my background is finance, I worked at the Philadelphia Stock Exchange and as a trader trainee and then after that I moved into a big corporation and then basically become a, but we love to travel of course and as a finance executive I was really busy and on my vacation I wanted to have the right vacation and at that time I found it very challenging. I was offered, you know, I felt like it was McDonald's menu, take menu one two and I would book the thing for you, so you arrive at destination, it's not the right hotel, maybe too quiet, too much of something or whatever. I said with my wife who was already in the travel industry that we will create a company that's actually focusing on tailor-made travel because everybody's different, some people like active vacation, some more cultural, some mix, some food and wine, some like to play golf during their vacation, everybody has his own and then that's what we focus on and that's how we started.

So 18 years after corporate world, I joined my wife and then we took Touring Treasures to a different level together, was fun, has been fun so far and we just enjoy creating those tailor-made itineraries, that was the promise that we gave ourselves when we started Touring Treasures is that that's why we exist and that's why the product is there, is to do this and we continue doing it and our clients love it. I mean we have some amazing tailor-made experiences that I can talk about, for example there was a lady from Singapore and I know she was celebrating her 25th anniversary and we, her husband told us that she loved the Australian pearls so we connected with Paspali Pearls and they opened their doors and then we created something very unique, very special where they could access with behind the scenes of how you actually farm a pearl and they went all the king pearlies with their seaplane and they were greeted at the flagship store, went through the vote and saw all the behind the scenes, of course she purchased some nice pearls so that was a good deal for Paspali but we created as well for some clients, we privatized part of the gallery of Southwest and then we, for some ladies who love art, food and wine, we incorporated a great chef creating a beautiful story within the gallery with them and what we did that was fun instead of having a boring, you know, a guide in the gallery, we basically incorporated a drag queen who is an expert in art so you can imagine how a drag queen, with the way she interprets things, that was really fantastic. So these are the things we like to do, we like really to go beyond, as I said, as long as it's legal we can do it and that's what we told our clients and that's our branding, Turing Treasures, as long as it's legal we can do it, we customize things and we take your trip to a different level.

And how can people find out more about Turing Treasures online, Olivier? You can just go to our website, turingtreasures.com, just make an inquiry, what we will do then reply to you and of course what we like is to connect with our guests, so we schedule a consultation and then it goes from there, once the consultation is done we know quite a lot about the client and we make a proposal and then the thing goes all the way, so and then we keep changing as long as it's required and then once it's done it's locked and this client's got his bespoke itinerary. Well it's been a wonderful pleasure talking to you, Olivier, mercy and for all from Turing Treasures Australia and thanks very much for being with us on Travel Radio Australia. Thank you, Travel Radio Australia, it was a pleasure.